

Mastura (Mim) Ritz

MES327: Seminar - Histories of Science, Nature, and the Body in the Middle East

Professor Susanna Ferguson

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Unveiling Queer Women Bodies in Lebanon: Empowerment and Agency in the Narratives of

Bareed Mista3jil

In a climate in which queer women are not allowed the liberty of expression, the body seeks alternative tools of resistance. The comprehension of the experience of Lebanese women whose sexuality and gender marks a deviance from that which is expected of them begins with an examination of the history and socio-political climate of the region. In exploring the narratives of the queer women included in *Bareed Mista3jil*, one witnesses the individual's ability to find emotional catharsis through both communal and singular storytelling. This release is found through the garnering of physical and emotional expression, which is most often gained through moments of vulnerability via divulging personal experiences. In doing so, they are also able to hone the authority and agency to be their own experts over their bodies and sexualities, and to find self-acceptance, allowing the strength of their queer existence to challenge the patriarchal society of Lebanon. In Iman Al-Ghfari's article, "The Lesbian Subjectivity in Contemporary Arabic Literature" she states that "after the emergence of Arab feminism, 'lesbian subjectivity' is totally silenced on the assumption that sexuality is not a 'priority' in a male-oriented world in which 'women' have more vital concerns to fight for than what is seen as

‘bodily rights’, or rights to ‘pleasure.’”¹ Al-Ghfari does not specify where in the Middle East that Arab feminism emerges, so she generalizes that all throughout the Middle East women, especially queer women, are looked down on when they view their bodies as places where sexuality and pleasure can exist. While this may be true and present in the Middle East, such judgements and prejudices of women and queer women are also present worldwide. Such judgements and prejudices though, have not always been the case in the Middle East. In Sahar Amer’s article “Naming to Empower: Lesbianism in the Arab Islamicate World Today” she says that “gender-bending has always been part of the Arabic language and Islamicate societies” and that in medieval Arab times “treatises on eroticism [that] depicted alternative sexualities openly, without shame, and considered them as one of the multiple facets of human sexuality in general.”² Homosexuality and discussion about sexuality of the body has been present in the Middle East since medieval times, and Arab feminism did not emerge until the late 19th century. So, such discussions were embraced by the general public at the time and onward, and these discussions have continued well into the 21st century which is seen with the women’s LGBTQ+ group in Lebanon: Meem. The group was founded in August of 2007. The purpose of the group is to create a safe space for queer identifying women in Lebanon, allowing for vulnerability and the growth of support systems. . So, at least in Lebanon, there is a supportive community for queer women to express their queerness and bodies.

Meem, which is shortened from Majmou3at Mou’azara lil Mar’a al-Mithliya, is the first lesbian and queer identifying women group, which includes “lesbians, bisexuals, transgender peoples, and queer and questioning women” in the Middle East. In order to be a member of

¹ Iman Al-Ghafari, "The Lesbian Subjectivity in Contemporary Arabic Literature." *Women and Photography in the Arab World*: 6 (2012-13): 6.

² Sahar Amer, "Naming to Empower: Lesbianism in the Arab Islamicate World Today." *Journal of Lesbian Studies* 16.4 (2012): 387.

Meem you must be a woman in the LGBTQ+ community and Lebanese, or living in Lebanon. As stated previously, the purpose of Meem is to create a safe space for queer identifying women in Lebanon. Such a space allows these queer women to be vulnerable and to support each other while living in a “patriarchal society where women’s issues are often dismissed.”³ In order to stand up against the Lebanese patriarchal society, Meem published a book in 2009 entitled: *Bareed Mista3jil*. The book is a collection of 41 different stories told by “lesbian, bisexual, transgender peoples, and queer and questioning women” from Lebanon.⁴ This book allows for autobiographical accounts about queer life for queer identifying women in Lebanon because Meem states that sexuality “is the ultimate taboo of women’s issues.”⁵ By creating such a book, they are allowing for these stories to be told in hopes that society can embrace differences in sexuality.

Despite discussions and texts of sexuality and homosexuality dating back to medieval Arab times it was not until the 21st century that these topics became taboo. It is the contemporary “political reappropriation of Islam by fundamentalist regimes”⁶ that have made these discussions less tolerable. At the end of the introduction of *Bareed Mista3jil*, they state that contemporary international politics have caused the Arab world to return to “traditional values and conservative moralities,”⁷ helping to make Lebanon into a patriarchal society. This causes sexuality to become “silenced” and “governed by shame and misconceived myths.”⁸ It is often the case that same-sex relationships are described in explicit terms, and at times there is agency over their sexual lives.⁹ Due to this, queer women in Lebanon have been “mocked, dismissed,

³ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories* (Beirut, Meem, 2009) 1.

⁴ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 2.

⁵ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 1.

⁶ Amer, "Naming to Empower: Lesbianism in the Arab Islamicate World Today," 387.

⁷ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 5.

⁸ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 5.

⁹ Amer, "Naming to Empower: Lesbianism in the Arab Islamicate World Today," 387.

denied, oppressed, distorted, and forced into hiding”¹⁰ because of their sexuality. This is why Meem and their book *Bareed Mista3jil* are powerful tools of resistance against such oppressions and allow queer women to embrace their sexualities, in whatever form that is. Meem themselves state in the introduction of *Bareed Mista3jil* that sexuality “touches upon reclaiming our bodies and demanding the right to desire and pleasure.”¹¹ The ethos championed by Meem and that is exemplified in *Bareed Mista3jil* serves as a catalyst for resisting societal oppressions and embracing diverse sexualities, as articulated in their assertion that sexuality is inherently linked to reclaiming autonomy over our bodies and asserting our rights to desire and pleasure.

Bareed Mista3jil is made up of 41 different and personal stories. Each of the different stories highlight different themes which are: discrimination, self-esteem, gender-identity, activism, coming out, family, relationships, sexual diversity, religion, community, self-discovery, and emigration. The theme, sometimes themes, of each story are bolded before each of the stories begin to help give the reader an idea of what the story will be about and what topics are present; either fully or partially. Meem wanted *Bareed Mista3jil* to be broken up into chapters, with each chapter being focused on one of the particular, broad themes, but did not do so “the stories refused to be tied down to any one single chapter.”¹² In agreement, these stories cannot be limited to one particular theme; in similarity, sexuality is also unable to be discussed in one particular way. It is something that resides in the body, mind, and soul. Expressions of sexuality can be seen physically such as how one dresses, sexual or romantic pleasure, or even vulnerability through emotions. There is always an aspiration to be able to express oneself and sexuality as they truly believe it to be. Such forms of expressing sexuality are seen in many ways, as with the 41 different stories in *Bareed Mista3jil*. The queer women storytellers of

¹⁰ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 1.

¹¹ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 1.

¹² Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 11.

Bareed Mista3jil are able to open up and tell their personal stories while being able to express their sexualities through their bodies, whether it be physically, emotionally, or by being vulnerable. In doing so, they are also able to hone the authority and agency to be their own experts over their bodies and sexualities, and to find acceptance in their queer bodies, allowing their homosexuality to challenge the patriarchal society of Lebanon.

The empowering narratives shared by the queer women storytellers of *Bareed Mista3jil* not only enable them to assert their agency over their bodies and sexualities but also serve as a poignant challenge to the established patriarchy of Lebanese society. This defiance against societal norms is strikingly evident in the story “We Live in a Ruthless Society”, where the storyteller's brother encapsulates the harsh reality of society with the phrase “Mojtama3na ma byir7am”, which translates to “our society is cruel and merciless.”¹³ In doing so, she reveals the challenges faced by queer women navigating their sexual identities within their families and communities. The storyteller recounts her experience coming out to her family, specifically their mother. Their mother makes many comments on her overall physical appearance. The storyteller says that “my mother thinks I’m a lesbian because I am overweight”¹⁴ and how her mother believes that “if I made a little more effort with the way I dressed and acted, I could easily land myself a husband.”¹⁵ So, the mother believes that if her daughter were to try harder to be a woman in how she appears physically, then she would not be a lesbian and therefore find a man. By the storyteller dressing to physically appear as more masculine, her mother believes her to be lesbian or queer, which shows that the mother understands sexuality to be expressed physically. Although there is nothing necessarily wrong about a woman dressing more masculine, the mother views this in a more derogatory way; in other words, that not putting effort into one’s

¹³ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 158.

¹⁴ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 158.

¹⁵ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 158.

appearance to seem more masculine or being overweight equates to being queer and not being idealized by men. This shows that the mother very much follows societal norms, and is fearful to challenge these norms; which feeds into the patriarchal and traditional values set in place.

The influence of Lebanese society also sheds light on how these preconceived notions of homosexuality intersect with discussions surrounding medicine and the body. This is exemplified again in the story “We Live in a Ruthless Society” when the storyteller states that there was an (unnamed) Arab television show that had an episode about homosexuality with “expert opinions from psychologists, sociologists, and health professionals.”¹⁶ She was particularly interested in having her mother also watch with her, to try to “help change her mentality”¹⁷ by trying to show that medical experts believe that homosexuality is normal and natural, and that there is nothing to be worried about or to view differently about someone who is queer. Unfortunately after watching for only a short time, her mother said that she was “the one who needed a *real* psychologist.”¹⁸ As a society we deem psychologists, sociologists, and health professionals to be the societal experts in terms of medicine, body, and society. They are who the general public listens to to get “expert” advice, but in this instance the mother does not even agree with these experts of the body. Rather, she wants her daughter to see a “real” psychologist, which can be deemed as a psychologist who does not normalize homosexuality. The mother believes that the “real” experts are the ones who agree with her and her opinions.

This contrast between the mother’s perception of a “real” psychologist and the broader societal view of expertise in terms of the body, prompts a deeper inquiry into the expertise and authority in matters concerning our own bodies; posing the question: who really is the expert of the body? When it comes to our own body, is its utmost expert a doctor? Society believes that

¹⁶ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 157.

¹⁷ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 157.

¹⁸ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 157.

experts over the body are doctors, psychologists, and sociologists, which in a way is true because they hone the skills and knowledge to understand and heal bodies. Many of these experts, though, are men. In the introduction of Sherine Hamdy's book *Our Bodies Belong to God: Organ Transplants, Islam, and the Struggle for Human Dignity in Egypt*, Hamdy interviews people with medical and religious authority about the ethics of organ transplantation. She states that many of the "expert" voices are male.¹⁹ Although Hamdy is referring specifically to Egypt in this instance, due to patriarchy of the Middle East, many of these same experts are likely mostly men in Lebanon. With the preconceived notions of homosexuality and women's sexualities, what authority do male experts have over a queer woman's body and their sexuality? Even though these doctors are "experts" in medicine, they do not have autonomy over a queer woman's body or sexuality. These doctors are unable to feel and experience the body and sexuality in the same way as a queer woman. It is these queer women storytellers of *Bareed Mista3jil* that are experts over their own bodies, and are able to reclaim their sexuality and assert their right to desire and pleasure as a means to challenge the patriarchal societal norm present in Lebanon.

Continuing the discussion of reclaiming autonomy over one's body and sexuality, the narrative in the story "Translebanon" delves into the experience of a trans-man in Lebanon, highlighting the complexities of gender identity within the societal framework. Their journey underscores the inherent dissonance between assigned physicality and innate gender identity which challenges the notion of expertise and authority over one's body. The storyteller recounts how they are a trans-man and how they have always known that they are a man. Despite having been born a woman, they are very hopeful about their future getting to finally be able to be a man. They open up their story by saying, "I believe that transsexuals are born that way: in the

¹⁹ Sherine Hamdy, "Introduction: Bioethics Rebound." In *Our Bodies Belong to God: Organ Transplants, Islam, and the Struggle for Human Dignity in Egypt* (University of California Press, 2012), 9.

wrong body.”²⁰ This is followed by the statement: “It all started at the age of five... that’s when I first discovered that there was something wrong with me,”²¹ which highlights that they knew by intuition at a young age that they were not born in the right body as a woman, but rather as a man. This suggests that sexuality, for them, is not just expressed by the physicality of the body but also via intuition and spirituality. Although they are changing their body in a very physical way by undergoing various surgeries to become a man and despite facing hardships from their family, friends, and the general society of Lebanon, they were able to believe in their sexuality and gender enough to give them the hope to be able to transition and change into their true self. They even say that “I have always identified as a boy.”²² Showing that for some of Meem’s authors, the concept of sexuality in the body is not always shown by the physicality of an individual but rather an instinctual feeling and the aspiration that one day it can be sought through and that one can be able to express such sexuality, physically.

Moving from the exploration of gender identity and its relationship to sexuality in the context of undergoing physical transition surgeries, the narrative in the story “My Forgotten Penis” shifts to another storyteller’s experience of self-discovery within the confines of societal gender norms and stereotypes. The storyteller recounts her self-discovery of lesbianism and realizing that she is a lesbian, rather than a boy. She states that even at a young age she “always thought I should’ve been born a boy.”²³ As a child, she says that “I was bombarded with rules and stereotypes about gender” and that “it was always a boy/ girl dichotomy.”²⁴ The storyteller cut her hair short, played soccer, and climbed rocks, all of which fit into a boy stereotype, and since she was bombarded about these stereotypes, she deduced that she was a boy and not a girl.

²⁰ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 130.

²¹ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 130.

²² Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 130.

²³ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 206.

²⁴ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 206.

This early recognition of their gender identity is rooted in the experience of being inundated with rigid gender norms and stereotypes from a young age, which fosters a binary perception of gender roles that can feel restrictive and confining. As a result of being inundated with these rigid gender norms, she found herself conforming to behaviors typically associated with boys, leading her to identify more closely with a boy rather than a girl. She was also taught that “boys love girls and girls love boys and that’s the way the world works,”²⁵ so when she began to develop feelings for girls she believed that it could only mean that she was actually a boy. This is a logical train of thought due to what society was telling her as a child. As a result, she states: “I figured that God had probably forgotten my penis but would fix me when I grew up. I found comfort in the thought that I was really a boy stuck in the wrong physical body. It meant I was different, but at least it made sense.”²⁶ Although the storyteller believed themselves to be “different”, even as a child her instinctive feelings about her body and identity gave her the hope and aspiration to be able to affirm her identity while going against any stereotypes, such as dressing and acting more masculine. She does this in order to affirm herself. Therefore, her perception of love and attraction, shaped by the societal expectations set in place and integrated in them at a young age, reinforced her belief in her male identity, causing her to interpret her feelings for girls as affirmation. This sense of being “stuck in the wrong physical body” provides a sense of understanding amid the uncertainty, providing reassurance that her true self would eventually align with her physical form. It was not until the storyteller was 10 years old that she identified as a lesbian. This is because she “stumbled upon a segment on cable TV that showed two men getting married.”²⁷ After watching this she says that there was a “feeling of excitement

²⁵ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 206.

²⁶ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 206.

²⁷ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 207.

that raced down my spine.”²⁸ By witnessing two men getting married, she deduced that two women can also get married – meaning that women can love other women. So she claimed the term lesbian. She claims that everything in her life started to make sense, and says: “My body was not a mistake; I really am a girl.”²⁹ With the new identity as a lesbian and feeling secure as a girl she now felt “natural and real and normal,”³⁰ and as an adult still continues to dress and act more masculine: “as I grew older, my behavior and my interests didn’t change.”³¹ This newfound understanding brought clarity and acceptance to her perception of her body and sexuality, instilling a sense of authenticity and normalcy in her life. Even into adulthood, she continued to express themselves in a masculine manner, finding comfort and stability in her identity as a lesbian woman.

In both of the stories “We Live in a Ruthless Society” and “My Forgotten Penis”, both of the storytellers are lesbian women who choose to physically appear more masculine. They are both able to express themselves through their appearance, giving them the authority to use their bodies as a means of self-expressing their sexualities. In doing so, they are able to go against the stereotypes and norms that society sets in place. In the chapter “Same-sex Relations in Modern Arabic Fiction Between Empowerment and Impossibility: A Case Study of Samar Yazbek’s *Cinnamon*” from Rima Sadek’s book *Memory, Voice, and Identity*, Sadek is mainly discussing modern Arabic literature, but also draws on how what is written in literature is also present in Arab societies. She states that women use their bodies as a performance and “performances that don’t conform to the dominant heteropatriarchal norms constitute a subversive political act, a moment of change.”³² This suggests that expressions of the body, and using the body as a site of

²⁸ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 207.

²⁹ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 207.

³⁰ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 207.

³¹ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 207.

³² Rima Sadek, “Same-sex Relations in Modern Arabic Fiction Between Empowerment and Impossibility: A Case Study of Samar Yazbek’s *Cinnamon*,” *Memory, Voice, and Identity* (Routledge, 2021): 106.

resistance, can help to serve as catalysts for change. This parallels the experiences of the storytellers from *Bareed Mista3jil* because they assert their identities through their body via physical appearance and self-expression, and challenge the societal constraints in Lebanon. In Dima E. Kaedbey's dissertation: "Building Theory Across Struggles: Queer Feminist Thought From Lebanon", she states that in Lebanon there is a "long tradition of repressing gender non-conforming peoples and sexualities that fall outside of the (monogamous, marriage) heterosexual norm."³³ The storytellers' physical appearance does "fall outside" of the norm set in place. They reclaim ownership over their bodies and go against the norms imposed on them. Thus, their stories not only highlight the intersectionality of the body through gender and sexuality, and societal expectations, but they also exemplify the transformative power of individual expression in shaping cultural discourse. As such, these discourses happen within the storytellers' communities such as family and friends. These storytellers use their bodies as a means of expression and in doing so are able to not only be brave to make a stance against society, but are also able to use their bodies as a means of physical and emotional vulnerability – by not following the "norm". With the storyteller in "We Live in a Ruthless Society", her vulnerability causes disruption and tension with her mother. The individual is not the sole scale for sexuality, but rather that there are outside factors like family and society. When considering an individual's sexuality, factors beyond the individual themselves, such as family and society, can help to influence perceptions and means of expression. For the two storytellers, their own individual experiences and characteristics play a significant role in shaping their sexuality – such as presenting more masculine, but external factors such as family and society also help to

³³ Dima E. Kaedbey, *Building Theory Across Struggles: Queer Feminist Thought from Lebanon* (Doctoral dissertation, Ohio State University, 2014), 13.

contribute to how their sexual identity as seen through their bodies is perceived and understood within societal contexts.

Building on the individual experiences of the storytellers, societal perceptions of sexual identity extend beyond personal characteristics, encompassing broader categorizations such as “butch” and “femme,” each carrying its own set of gendered expectations and representations within the lesbian community. Even within the lesbian community, there is also a binary: butch being more masculine, and femme being more feminine and girly. The appearance of a butch is usually short hair and masculine clothes, whereas femme is usually long hair and feminine clothes. In the story “Butch” the storyteller recounts her experience being a butch, and how for a period of time she appeared more femme to fit in more with the lesbian community, after having a bad experience meeting another lesbian. The storyteller, as well as other queer people in Lebanon, meet other queer people online in chat rooms, such as the #gaylebanon chat room.³⁴ Usually after these online chats, then do people begin to meet in real life, usually for sex but also just to actually meet and talk – not dissimilar to a date. The storyteller says that she “loathed the word ‘butch’.”³⁵ This is because she found it difficult to talk to other lesbians in person. When she went to meet another lesbian for the first time after meeting in the chat room, she “wished that somehow she would find me beautiful,”³⁶ later saying that “‘beautiful’ was an adjective alien to my image of myself that I never thought that it was possible that anyone would ever find me attractive.”³⁷ She hated the term “butch” because she associated butches with acting macho, having loud voices, and being fat. She also says that “I had short hair, dressed in baggy jeans and loose t-shirts, and was overweight, I was a butch despite myself. And therefore I was ugly.”³⁸ She

³⁴ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 150.

³⁵ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 150.

³⁶ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 150.

³⁷ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 150.

³⁸ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 151.

believed that butches were ugly, and since she physically appeared as butch she too believed that she was ugly. Although she herself did not ever want to label herself as a butch, due to her physical appearance and overall mannerisms the label was placed on her. While growing up, the stereotypes of men that butches also claimed, were strongly engraved in her head. If a woman, especially a queer woman, did not physically appear as feminine, such as being girly, sensitive, soft, and having long hair, then they were deemed as ugly. Taking these ideas to head and heart, the storyteller was apprehensive to meet this other lesbian in person since the other lesbian would see that she was butch; and unfortunately the meeting went “horrible.”³⁹ After the meeting she says that “my already low self-esteem plummeted even further,”⁴⁰ also saying “why would lesbians feel attracted to manly women?”⁴¹. With this idea in mind, as well as a low self-esteem she began to change her appearance to seem more feminine. In doing so, she stopped cutting her hair short, grew out her fingernails and painted them, made her clothes more form fitting, and sometimes put on makeup – all to present as more femme or feminine.⁴² After this change in appearance, she went to meet with another lesbian. This lesbian, though, was butch. She was excited about this saying that “now she can fall in love with me because I am girly.”⁴³ The storyteller conforms to the societal norms of how women should look and act in order to experience love and desire, despite usually appearing more masculine. She allowed the pressures of societal standards of femininity and womanhood to conform to a more physically feminine version of herself, even if that meant compromising her authentic self. Despite dressing the opposite of her authentic, masculine self, she says that she “felt more confident and did more

³⁹ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 151.

⁴⁰ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 151.

⁴¹ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 151.

⁴² Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 151.

⁴³ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 151.

talking that time,”⁴⁴ but at the same time “felt awkward,”⁴⁵ which was evident to who she was meeting with. She admits that she felt a temporary boost in confidence, however she also acknowledges a feeling of discomfort. This highlights that there was an internal conflict between conforming to societal expectations and staying true to herself.

The internal conflict between conforming to societal expectations and staying true to oneself is also echoed in discussions about the female body and sexuality within Arab feminism. Kaedbey says that in discussions about the female body and sexuality, through the lens of Arab feminism, the body is seen as a place of “pain and hurt”⁴⁶ instead of “sovereignty and healthy sexual practices.”⁴⁷ This notion of discomfort and unease with one’s authentic self is also reflected in the storyteller in “Butch”. She does not feel comfortable with her authentic masculine presentation, but she also does not feel comfortable by appearing feminine – so she is experiencing a profound sense of pain and hurt, with the feeling of being ugly and not being able to be loved. While at her meeting with the other butch lesbian, the other lesbian could see that she felt awkward presenting as more feminine. This sparked a conversation about butch and femme, which to the other lesbian said “butches and femmes are just replications of traditional society’s male/ female rules”⁴⁸ and that is “was actually stupid of us to follow them.”⁴⁹ The storyteller “listened to her passionately.”⁵⁰ This conversation between the two caused the storyteller to start her own journey to self-discovery, by which she says “I badly wanted to see myself as cool and beautiful. I wanted to be the butch woman I really was and not be overwhelmingly embarrassed by it.”⁵¹ Taking the conversation to heart, the storyteller continues

⁴⁴ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 151.

⁴⁵ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 152.

⁴⁶ Kaedbey, *Building Theory Across Struggles: Queer Feminist Thought from Lebanon*, 52.

⁴⁷ Kaedbey, *Building Theory Across Struggles: Queer Feminist Thought from Lebanon*, 52.

⁴⁸ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 152.

⁴⁹ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 152.

⁵⁰ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 152.

⁵¹ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 152.

to accept herself as a butch lesbian, while at the same time trying to erase the butch and femme dichotomies that are set in place for lesbians by society. The storyteller is learning to become an expert of her own body, to be able to express herself and her body as she wishes to be in order to be beautiful and to experience her own queer desire and pleasure.

In the story “My Own Private Revolution”, the storyteller is bisexual and she narrates her story of coming to love her body. Throughout her life, even from a young age, she was engaging in relationships with older men in order to please them and to feel desired. This started at the age of 7 where she consented to having a relationship with a 40 year old man. She “wanted to please him”⁵² and “gave him what he desired for three years.”⁵³ Similar relationships continued on into her life, but it was not until the age of 15 that she started to have sex. This caused her body to become a “source of shame.”⁵⁴ At the age of 15 she entered puberty and wanted to use tampons for when she was menstruating. Her mother and a gynecologist told her that she used tampons then her “vagina would turn into a wide, gaping hole,”⁵⁵ which her future husband would “find no pleasure in it.”⁵⁶ Both her mother and the gynecologist, who is an expert of the female body, not only told her that her actions are supposed to please men, but also that it was expected of her to get a husband. Her actions even as an adolescent are supposed to appease to men, even well into the future. This gives into the fact that Lebanon is a patriarchal society and that women are to not only live up to the standards of men, but also to serve them with their bodies. At the age of 19, the storyteller was raped in a car by two men causing more pain to her body where she says: “Why couldn’t my body disappear?”⁵⁷ showing that her sexual relations with men and giving into their desire was hurting her and her body. After this encounter she began to seek

⁵² Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 217.

⁵³ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 217.

⁵⁴ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 217.

⁵⁵ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 218.

⁵⁶ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 218.

⁵⁷ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 219.

relationships with women, but even in the queer community she found that many other women felt discomfort in their bodies. She states that “all this hatred and disgust, it was in all of us.”⁵⁸ This is because some queer women were uncomfortable to be naked, some were unable to orgasm because they felt discomfort in their own skin, and some women refused to let her take their pants off because they had unshaved legs.⁵⁹ It is not necessarily that these women are not attracted to other women, but that they feel discomfort in being able to express their queer identity through their bodies. The storyteller claims that all women carry self-hatred in them and that there is “this unspoken burden that we cannot distance ourselves from because it touches at the very core of who we are as women”⁶⁰ because some women are afraid to want, leak, be happy, be hairy, or be chubby.⁶¹ By growing up and having family members and even doctors talk about women needing to appease men, as seen when the storyteller goes to the gynecologist, it makes women uncomfortable to be women. With queer women, not only do they find discomfort being women while living in a patriarchal society but they are also unable to truly express their identities and be able to experience desire and pleasure through sex. They are afraid to go against the grain of society and be able to feel desire or to have physical features that can be seen as unwomanly. Drawing from the story “Butch” this can be due to queer women not feeling beautiful or desirable enough to even other women, who share similar feelings. The storyteller finishes her story by saying:

“This was my own personal revolution: I vowed to love my body. I vowed to own it, to let only myself decide how and where and with whom and when to have sex. I vowed to say no when I didn’t want sex. I vowed to allow myself to enjoy the pleasure my body

⁵⁸ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 219.

⁵⁹ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 219.

⁶⁰ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 219.

⁶¹ Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 220.

could give me, and not just what other people could use it for. I vowed to never let a woman speak ill of her body, to tell her about the freedom that comes with letting go of the lies she is fed about it. This was my revolution, and it is still in the making.”⁶²

She feels empowered by how she herself and other women find discomfort in their bodies to stand up to this discomfort and shame, and to go on the path of feeling okay in her own body. In Sarah Hamdan’s article “Re-Orienting Desire from With/in Queer Arab Shame: Conceptualizing Queer Arab Subjectivities Through Sexual Difference Theory in a Reading of Bareed Mista3jil” she states that the storytellers of *Bareed Mista3jil* “refuse to abide to the binary choice of rejecting traditional, unmodern shame (by opposing tradition and their family) and embracing modern, sexual freedom.”⁶³ This is especially seen with the storyteller in “My Own Private Revolution”. She vows to make her own decisions for and about her body, and wants to be able to feel pleasure and desire. She is using her body as a way to challenge society and to try to finally be comfortable with herself and to be able to express her sexuality freely. In navigating the complexities of societal expectations and personal identity, the storyteller's journey in the story exemplifies a powerful assertion of agency and self-acceptance, demonstrating the transformative potential of embracing one's own body and desires as a means of challenging societal norms and finding liberation.

The queer women storytellers of *Bareed Mista3jil* use their narratives as a means to express their sexualities through their bodies, despite living in patriarchal Lebanon. They are able to be their own experts over their bodies and challenge societal norms. In Rachel Bailey Jones and Shawgi Tell’s chapter “Sexuality in the Arab World: Complexity and Contradiction”,

⁶² Meem, *Bareed Mista3jil: True Stories*, 220.

⁶³ Sarah Hamdan. "Re-Orienting Desire from With/in Queer Arab Shame: Conceptualizing Queer Arab Subjectivities Through Sexual Difference Theory in a Reading of Bareed Mista3jil." *Kohl: A Journal for Gender and Body Research* 1.1 (2015): 60.

they state that “the body, as the most visible symbol of sexuality, is a place for intersecting political and aesthetic arguments, and women in the Arab world are constantly negotiating these arguments.”⁶⁴ The narratives present in *Bareed Mista3jil* draw on the complex interplay between sexuality, gender identity, and societal norms in Lebanon. By sharing their personal stories, the queer women storytellers are able to reclaim agency over their bodies and challenge traditional gender roles imposed by society. Jones and Tell’s assertion regarding the body as a site of intersecting politics and aesthetic resonates deeply with the experience depicted in these narratives. In the context of Lebanon, queer women navigate a space where societal expectations intersect with personal desire, leading to negotiation of identity and autonomy. Through their narratives, the storytellers in *Bareed Mista3jil* help to contribute to this ongoing dialogue, shedding light on the diverse experiences of queer individuals and the complexities of navigating sexuality within a patriarchal society. These women open up their bodies through storytelling, as a way to redefine norms and to resist the power dynamics present in Lebanese society. Their vulnerable and personal stories serve as powerful resilience and strength inherent in embracing one's true self, despite the challenges posed by societal constraints.

⁶⁴ Rachel Bailey Jones and Shawgi Tell. “Chapter 9: Sexuality in the Arab World: Complexity and Contradiction,” *Counterpoints* 355 (2010): 135

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